

While studying smallpox—a virus that killed 400,000 people a year in 18th-century Europe—British doctor Edward Jenner established the technique of vaccination, which has since saved billions of lives. His smallpox vaccine, the world's first successful vaccine, eventually led to the total eradication of the disease.

MILESTONES

BECOMES FELLOW

Elected to the Royal Society in 1789, partly for discovering how cuckoos remove eggs from nests.

GIVES VACCINE

Administers and documents the first successful smallpox vaccination in 1796.

SUBMITS PAPER

Presents his initial findings to the Royal Society in 1797. The scientific academy requests further proof.

COMPLETES STUDY

Publishes a complete report of his experiment in 1798. His paper is met by a mix of interest and disbelief.

CHANGES POLICY

British government finally accepts his evidence and makes vaccination its official policy in 1853.

Edward Jenner was born in the county of Gloucestershire, the eighth of nine children. From the age of 5, following the death of his clergyman father, he was brought up by one of his older brothers. As a youth, he had his first brush with smallpox—the disease that would mark his future career—when he became ill after undergoing variolation. This form of inoculation involved inserting pus or a scab from a patient with mild smallpox into a scratch or the nostrils of a healthy person to boost their immunity. Although it was a popular treatment among the aristocracy in Europe, it carried a high risk of onward transmission or even death.

Medical training

Jenner was apprenticed to a local surgeon at the age of 14 and moved to London 8 years later to become a private pupil of John Hunter, a leading surgeon, anatomist, and biologist known for his scientific methods and groundbreaking experiments. A mentor and friend for

**“One of
the greatest
benefactors
of mankind.”**

Napoleon Bonaparte



Jenner demonstrated the link between cowpox and smallpox by conducting careful medical trials. His 1798 report detailed his treatment of 23 patients, including several children.